“After the recruiter explained, I just blurted out *yes*. Now, it’s sinking in.” A shadow passed over Juliette’s face. She twisted the edge of her blouse between her fingers. “Do you think I made the right choice?”

All Léa knew was that Juliette had made her choice for the right reason. Wasn’t that the most important? “Yes,” she said, “you’re not hurting anyone but helping Raphael and your mother.”

“That’s what I think.” Juliette smiled. “Thank you.”

“Juliette, come back inside,” a woman on the stairs called out. “It’s cold, you’ll get sick.”

Léa watched the women stamp their cigarettes under their shoes, then tuck them into their pockets for later.

“I’ve got to go,” Juliette said.

Léa didn’t want her to leave. “When will you go?”

“Tomorrow.” She stepped back from the fence. “Goodbye, Léa.”

“Goodbye, Juliette. Good luck.”

Léa walked. Something inside her galvanized. The last thing she wanted was for Rose to end up in a desperate situation, the way Juliette had. Alone. Without André or Léa. Her chest tightened at the frightening thought that Rose, left with no other choice, might fall into prostitution.

The farther she walked, the more her resolve hardened. Maître Mallon was right. Working in Germany—no matter the cost—would at least give her the means to keep herself and Rose safe. One year. She could endure it for her sister.

* * *

With each passing day, Léa’s determination grew stronger. Seeing the terrible conditions in the camp and the bad luck that brought so many here, she realized that working in Germany was her only way through the war.

A few days later, she stood at the gate, tightening the collar of her coat against the biting cold morning, hoping that today Rose and Maître Mallon would return. She looked out at the thick chalk-gray fog, feeling the dampness seep through her clothes. She could only see what was in front of her because a gray haze muffled the distant shapes, making everything feel faraway and uncertain. Now that Léa had decided, each day that Rose didn’t know felt awkward and strange, as if time had been suspended and